TRADE HUSTL3

Built by Hustle, Backed by Trades

ENTER • EARN • ELEVATE

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CHAPTER 1

WHAT A SKILLED TRADE REALLY IS

BEFORE I BECAME THE MAINTENANCE MAN

On my first day working in HVAC, I fell through an attic.

Not once.

Not twice.

Three times.

Three times in one day.

That was my introduction to the skilled trades.

There was no perfect first day. No walking onto the job already knowing what I was doing. No magic moment where somebody handed me a tool bag and suddenly I became the Maintenance Man.

The field humbled me immediately.

And looking back, I needed that.

Because before you become skilled, you have to be willing to be unskilled.

You have to be willing to say, "I don't know."

You have to listen.

You have to get corrected.

You have to learn how to move, how to think, how to work safely, how to use the tools, and how to stop making the same mistake twice.

That first day taught the Maintenance Man something that has stayed with me ever since:

There is a difference between having a job and having a skill.

A job can give you a paycheck.

A skill can give you leverage.

And once I understood that, I started looking at work differently.

That is what this book is about.

Not just getting hired.

Not just finding something to do after high school.

Not just making enough money to survive until Friday.

This is about building something that belongs to you.

Something you can improve.

Something you can carry into another company, another city, another position, another industry, and eventually—if that is your goal—into a business of your own.

That something is skill.

And skill changes the game.

So WHAT IS A SKILLED TRADE?

A skilled trade is hands-on work that requires training, practice, technical knowledge, problem-solving, safety awareness, judgment, and responsibility.

Read that again.

Because skilled trades are not just about being good with your hands.

Your hands are part of it.

Your brain is part of it too.

A skilled worker has to understand what they are looking at.

What they are hearing.

What they are measuring.

What changed.

What failed.

What could be dangerous.

And what needs to happen next.

Electricians keep power moving.

Plumbers keep clean water coming in and waste moving out safely.

HVAC technicians keep homes and buildings heated, cooled, and ventilated.

Welders join materials used in buildings, equipment, vehicles, and infrastructure.

Maintenance technicians keep apartment communities, schools, hospitals, factories, warehouses, hotels, offices, and other facilities operating.

Carpenters build.

Machinists create precision parts.

Pipe fitters assemble critical piping systems.

Equipment technicians keep machines running.

Industrial maintenance workers troubleshoot systems companies may depend on every minute of the day.

These workers are not "just working with their hands."

They are solving problems people depend on being solved correctly.

A skilled trade is a trained ability applied to a real-world problem.

That is why the word skilled matters.

HARD WORK MATTERS. SKILL CHANGES YOUR VALUE.

I am not going to lie to you about the trades.

There is hard work involved.

You may carry material.

Climb ladders.

Work in heat.

Work in the cold.

Get dirty.

Stand on your feet for hours.

Crawl into places you would rather not crawl into.

Start early.

Stay late.

Clean up after the work is finished.

Some days will test you.

That is real.

I am not going to sell you a fantasy where everybody walks into a trade, puts on a clean uniform, grabs a tool bag, and immediately starts making big money.

That is not how this works.

But physical effort is only one level of the game.

Anybody may be able to carry a box.

Fewer people know what is inside the box.

Fewer know where it goes.

Fewer know how it connects to the rest of the system.

Fewer understand what happens if it is installed incorrectly.

Fewer know how to test the finished work.

And fewer still can return six months later when the system stops working and figure out why.

That is skill.

A beginner may know how to remove a part.

A skilled technician starts asking different questions.

Why did that part fail?

Was the part really the problem?

What caused the failure?

Is something else damaged?
What measurements prove the diagnosis?
How do I repair this safely?
What needs to be checked before I leave?
That is a different level of thinking.
A person who only changes parts can stay busy.
A person who understands how to diagnose problems builds value.
Do not confuse motion with skill.
You can work hard all day and still not be getting better.
The goal is to work, learn, understand, and improve.

THE TOOLS ARE NOT THE TRADE

A lot of people notice the tools first.
The drills.
Meters.
Gauges.
Torches.
Welders.
Tool bags.
Work trucks.
Hard hats.
Work boots.
And yes, tools matter.
But owning tools does not make you skilled.
You can buy an expensive tool tomorrow.
You cannot buy ten years of knowledge tomorrow.
The real trade is what happens between your ears.
Knowledge.
Judgment.
Experience.
Problem-solving.
Pattern recognition.
Safety.
Communication.
Responsibility.
The tool helps you perform the work.
You are supposed to understand why you are using it.

That understanding separates somebody who knows how to perform one task from somebody who can solve a problem.

And solving problems is where your value starts growing.

WHAT MAKES A TRADE "SKILLED"?

A trade becomes skilled because the work requires more than effort.

It requires knowledge.

Standards.

Judgment.

And accountability.

Depending on the trade, you may need to understand:

Safety procedures.

Codes.

Manufacturer instructions.

Plans.

Specifications.

Electrical diagrams.

Measurements.

Airflow.

Pressure.

Temperature.

Materials.

Controls.

Mechanical systems.

Equipment operation.

Licensing requirements.

Permits.

You do not learn all of that overnight.

That is why training matters.

That is why repetition matters.

That is why experienced workers matter.

That is why proper supervision matters when you are learning.

And that is why shortcuts can become dangerous.

In some jobs, a mistake creates an inconvenience.

In the trades, a mistake can damage equipment.

Flood a building.

Create an electrical hazard.

Cause a fire risk.